Chapter One

The lighthouse had been dark for eleven years before Mira decided it was her problem. She had walked past it every morning of that time, and every morning it had looked back at her with the same patient indifference, and somewhere in the eleventh winter the arrangement stopped feeling neutral.

Her father would have called this a symptom. He had a whole vocabulary for the things people did instead of sleeping, instead of eating, instead of speaking to one another about the thing that had actually happened. Mira had inherited the vocabulary and almost none of the discipline that was supposed to come with it.

Chapter One

The door was not locked. That was the first surprise, and it reorganised the others behind it. She had prepared for a lock, had a crowbar in the boot of the car and a story ready for anyone who asked, and instead the handle turned with the small mechanical courtesy of a thing that has been waiting.

Inside, the air was colder than the air outside, which she had not expected and could not immediately explain. Salt had got into everything. The stairs went up in a spiral so tight it felt less like climbing than like being screwed slowly into the sky, and by the fourth turn she had lost any sense of which way the sea lay.